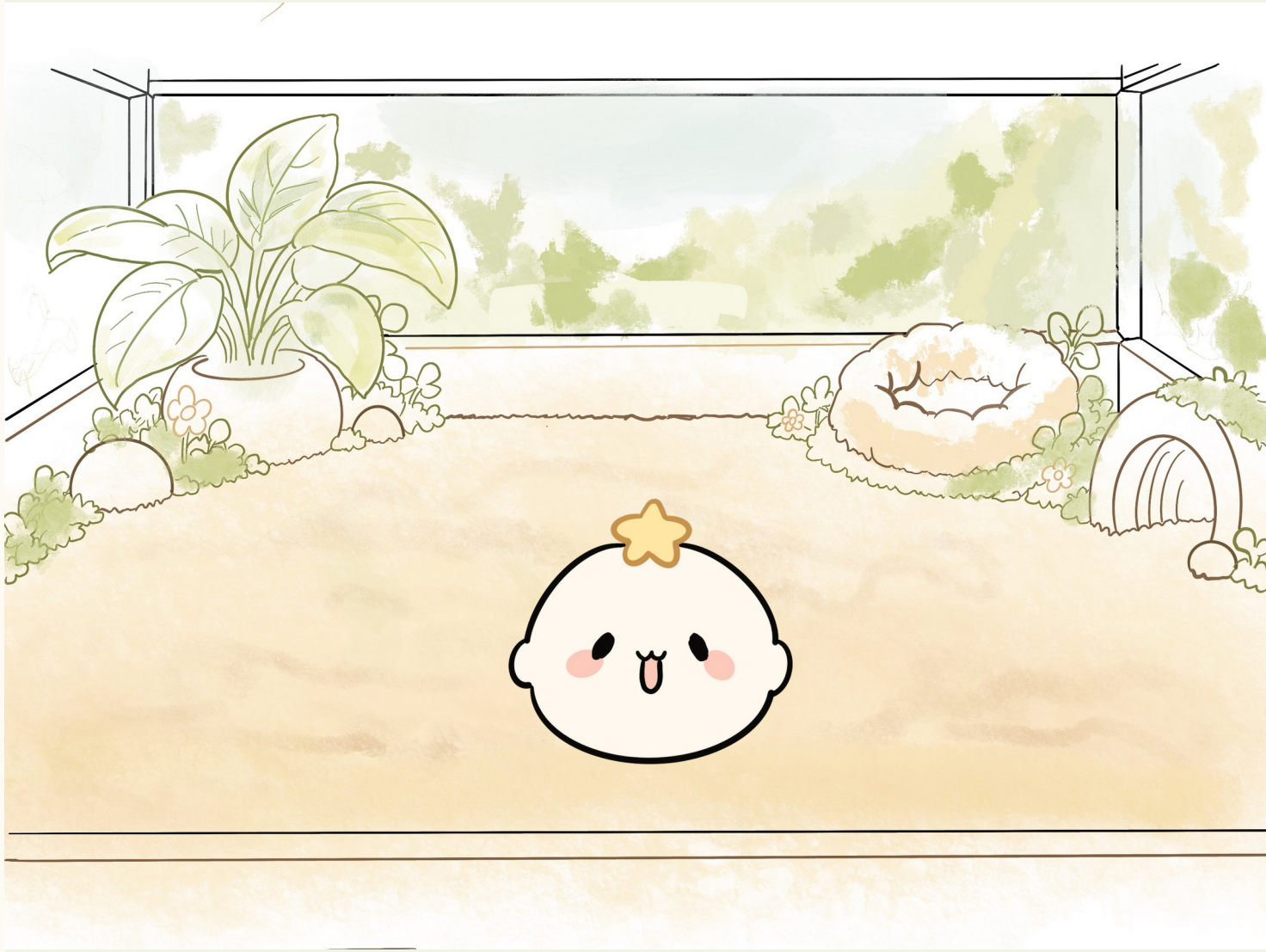
Little Rascal

A little life, shaped by care.

A playable virtual pet experience
built with p5.js



Can small acts of care create attachment?

How can caring for a simple pet create a meaningful connection?

Care → response → attachment

A short browser experience for a desktop or exhibition setting.



A companion with changing needs

Three layers of connection

01

VISCERAL

“I want to meet it.”

Soft colour, a cute silhouette and gentle sound.

02

BEHAVIOURAL

“My actions matter.”

Clear care tools, physical play and readable responses.

03

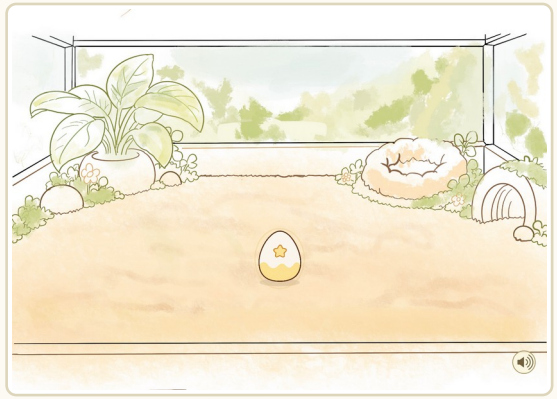
REFLECTIVE

“I cared for this little life.”

Naming, changing needs and a meaningful goodbye.

Design framework: Norman’s three levels of emotional design (2004).

From a first meeting to a new beginning



01

Meet & name

Click the egg.

Give a name.

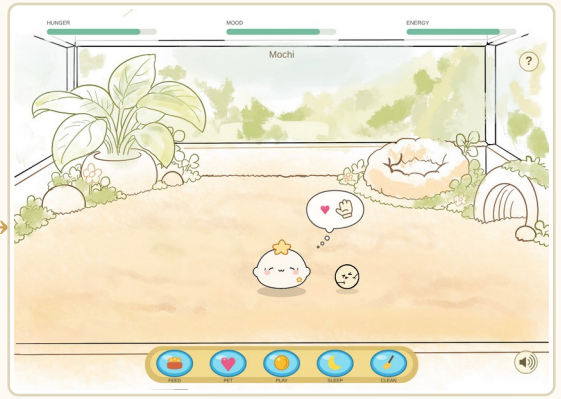


02

Care & respond

Read needs.

Choose how to care.



03

Grow & change

Care, then sleep.

Wake into the next stage.



04

Farewell & renew

Open the letter.

Welcome a new egg.

One character, three changing relationships



LITTLE ONE

Curious and dependent.
Immediate care feedback.



YOUTH

Playful and independent.
May resist or get bored.



SENIOR

Slower, with rest breaks.
Asks for affection.

Growth follows useful care and the next waking — not a passive age timer.

Care is a conversation, not a command



Accepts

Happy feedback rewards meaningful care.



Gets bored

Repetition or a full need can lead to stillness.

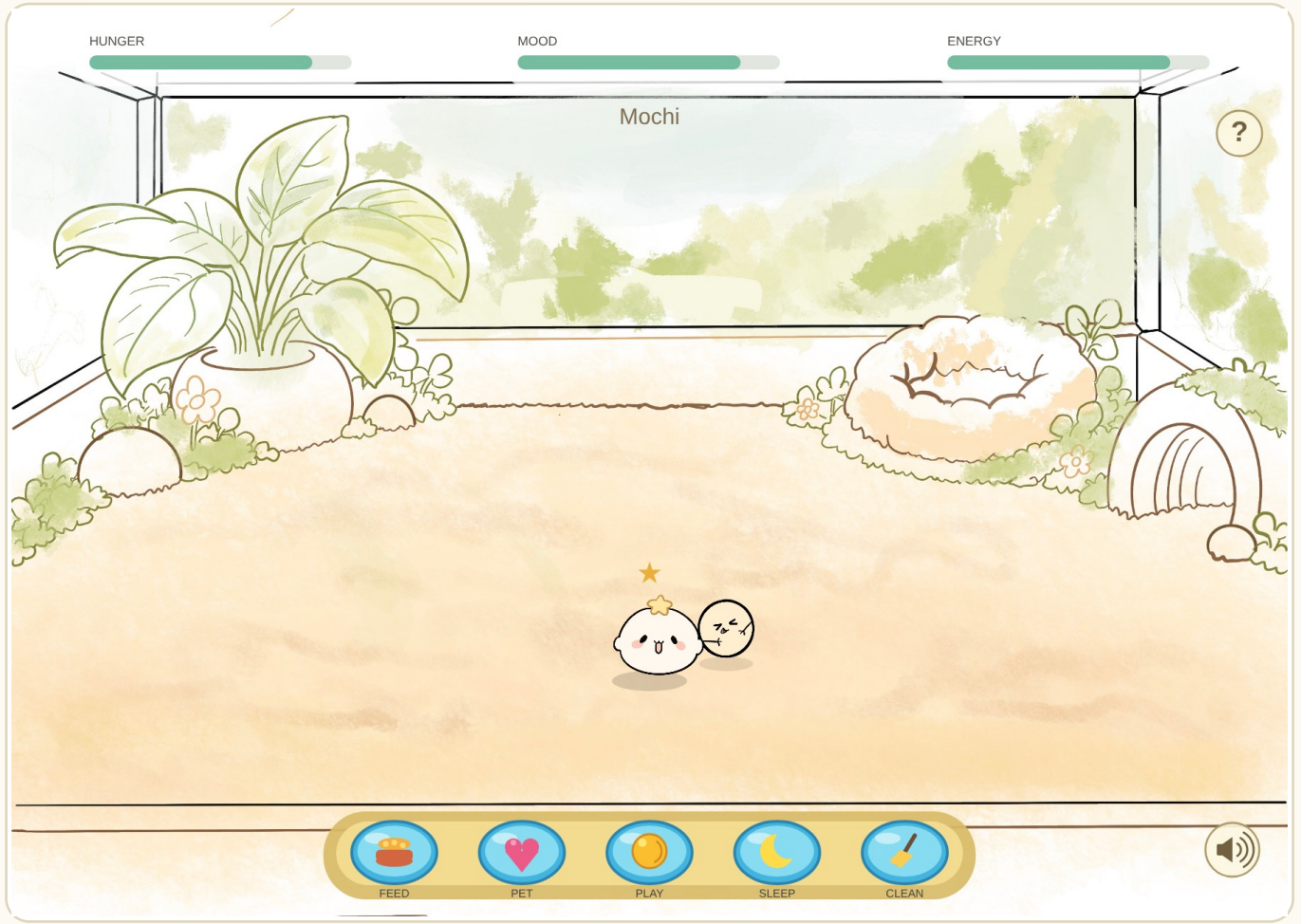


Refuses

An angry dodge or kick shows a clear boundary.

25% baseline refusal for Youth feeding, petting and play.

Bring interaction into the room



A toy in the room

Pick up → throw → chase → contact → kick



Needs become visible

Low hunger flattens the body.

Unclean waste brings distress.

A life in two minutes

00:00–00:25

Egg, hatch & naming

00:25–00:55

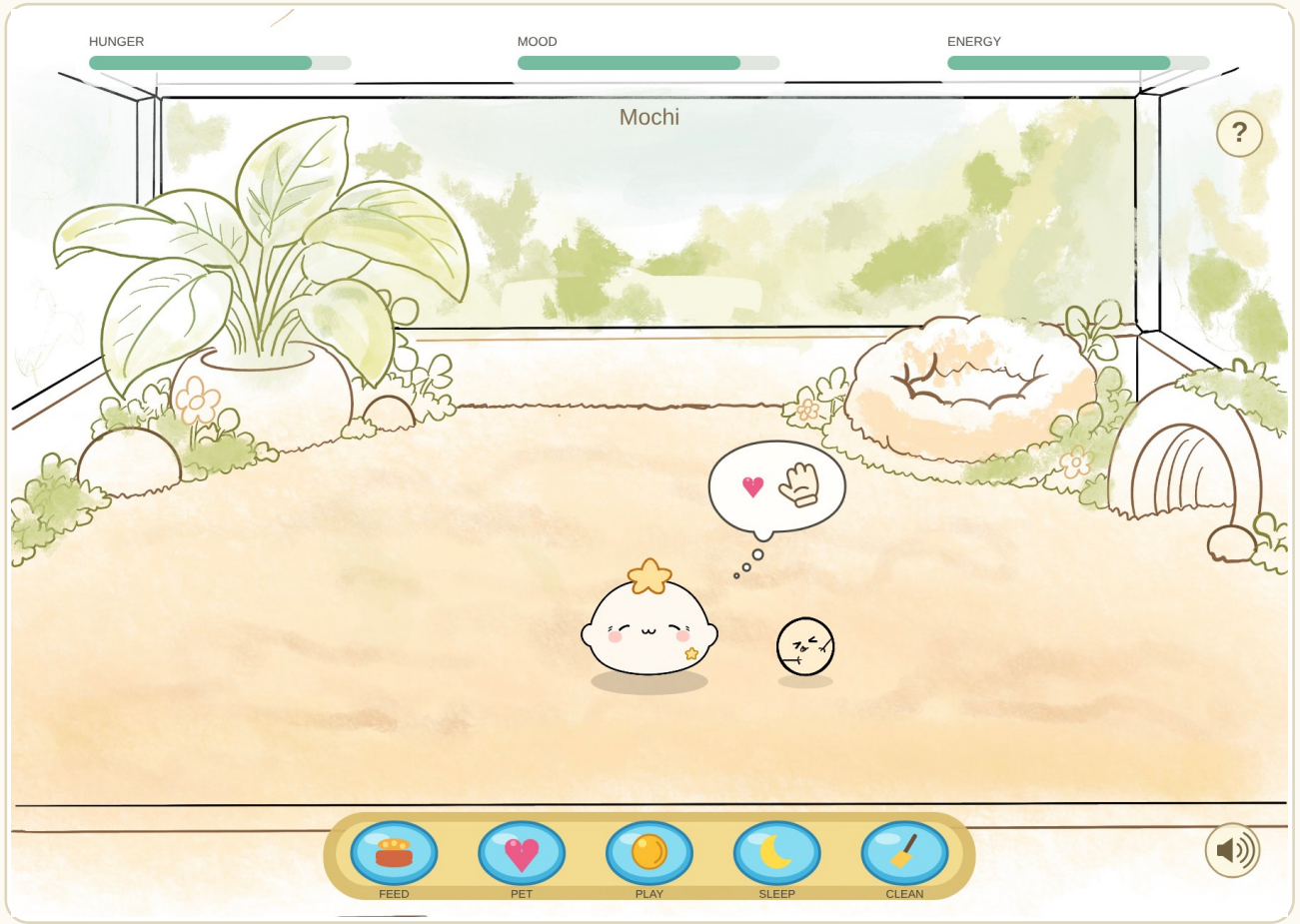
Care & physical play

00:55–01:25

Youth personality

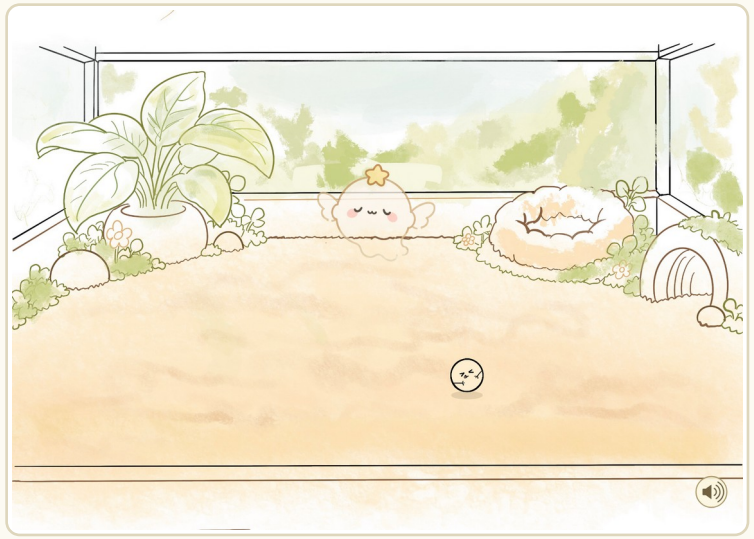
01:25–02:00

Senior & farewell

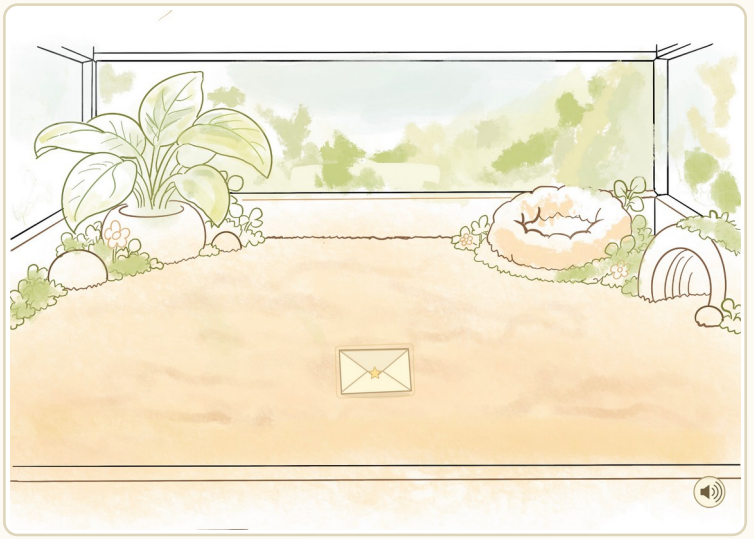


Edited walkthrough • use cuts between stages

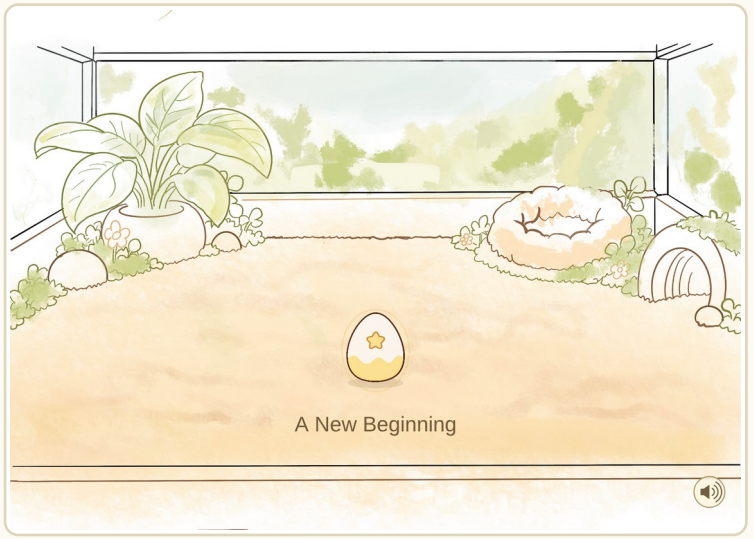
Let the player choose when to say goodbye



Letting go



An invitation to remember



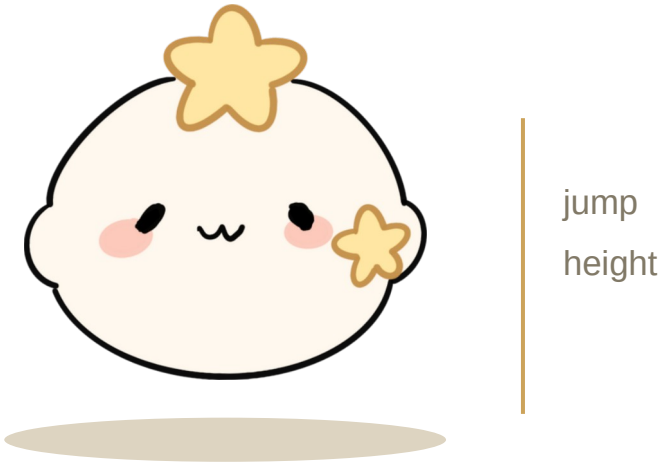
A new beginning

“I’m glad we met.”

The gratitude letter follows natural old age; neglect has a different ending.

Build spatial movement with 2D tools

Depth from 2D rules



Scale by depth • sort by floor Y • anchor shadows

State & care

sketch.js + stages.js

Physical toy

toy-ball.js + contact logic

Arrival & goodbye

hatching.js + ending.js

Help, naming & audio

Separate interface scripts

Make each reaction feel intentional

What changed

Toy play

Remote-looking pursuit → visible contact kick

Senior movement

Slow-motion feel → short hops and real rests

Farewell

Excessive flattening → gentle softening and a letter

What still needs testing

Do people discover dragging?

Can they understand a refusal?

Does the goodbye arrive too soon?

Next: audience testing, pacing, saved progress and accessibility.

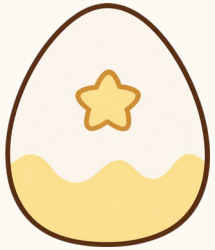
Current evidence: iterative playthroughs and automated browser checks; no formal audience study claimed.

A relationship built from small interactions

A small character.
A changing relationship.



Curiosity → care → attachment → goodbye → renewal



PLAY LITTLE RASCAL ↗️

itsangelia.github.io/little-rascal/

References and production credits

References & process transparency

DESIGN FRAMEWORK

Norman, D. A. (2004). Emotional Design: Why We Love (or Hate) Everyday Things. Basic Books.

IMPLEMENTATION

p5.js documentation — https://p5js.org/reference/

Little Rascal source — https://github.com/itsangelia/little-rascal

REFERENCE & ASSETS

My Lil' Bastard: supplied gameplay reference. Uploaded illustrations and iterated generated assets inform the final visual direction.

AI & AUDIO

OpenAI assistance: coding/debugging and image exploration. Final disclosure should follow course policy. Music: bgm.mp3 — original source and credit need confirmation.

Appendix • do not read aloud. Add your own exhibition evidence and personal reflection before submission.